

ARTS

Loyola College, Chennai, with its emphasis on freedom of thought retains the top position. Lady Shri Ram College moves to second place followed by St. Stephen's.



2009		2008	2007
>> 1	Loyola College, Chennai	1	1
^ 2	Lady Shri Ram College for Women, Delhi	5	3
>> 3	St. Stephen's College, Delhi	3	2
∇ 4	St. Xavier's College, Mumbai	2	4
^ 5	St. Xavier's College, Kolkata	9	5
>> 6	Christ College, Bangalore	6	8
∇ 7	Presidency College, Kolkata	4	6
>> 8	Madras Christian College, Chennai	8	9
^ 9	Stella Maris College, Chennai	10	11
∇ 10	Fergusson College, Pune	7	13

National rankings are derived from a combination of perceptual and factual scores. Colleges that did not provide factual information were not ranked. Faculties were not considered.

| By Nirmala Ravindran |

As he walks out of the principal's office, C. Rajashekar is all smiles. A Sri Lankan refugee, he landed in Chennai three months ago with no papers or wealth and is among the many aspirants who have obtained admission to enter the hallowed portals of Loyola College, Chennai this year. The 100-acre campus with tree-lined avenues housing the 85-year-old institution belies its status in the world of education with its austere and serene look. For Loyola takes its achievements in its stride. Topping the INDIA TODAY-NIELSEN best colleges survey in the arts stream for the third consecutive year, it continues to rule the roost not just at the local but national level as well, often serving as inspiration for policy decisions in the world of education. The top order saw some upheavals as Lady Shri Ram (LSR) College for Women, Delhi, worked its way up the order to the second position while St. Stephen's College, Delhi, retained its position at No. 3. While there was minor reshuffling among the top 10 colleges, Miranda House, Delhi, took impressive strides to reach the 11th rank.

For topper Loyola, it is an interdisciplinary approach to the humanities that continues to mark the curriculum. "We lay a lot of stress on the importance of freedom. Students cannot be bound by just an academic approach. To help them achieve the impossible, we have to let them fly," says the principal of Loyola College, Rev. Dr A. Albert Muthumalai. He estimates that a third of the students who complete their studies in arts and humanities at Loyola turn entrepreneurs, while a third pursue higher studies and research and the rest find gainful employment. Always a leader, Loyola has in the last decade changed its approach to education. Once considered an elitist college, Loyola today takes great pride in focusing on the poor and the needy. Besides accommodating refugees from Sri Lanka and Tibet, the college also makes an attempt to bring first generation learners into the mainstream. "We have some of the best faculty members and we use them to ensure that the first year in college is used to bridge the gap between students in terms of their past education and achievements," says Muthumalai.

The key to success lies in continuously reinventing itself. "We are now in the third phase of restructuring both our curriculum as well as governing policies," says Muthumalai. Thanks to this restructuring, the choice-based credit system introduced by Loyola has been adopted and implemented by the Government of Tamil Nadu across institutions. The other is the shift system.

PRINCIPALSPEAK Rev. Dr A. Albert Muthumalai, Loyola College, Chennai

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